

Harlem Renaissance Library Session

Grades 3–5

GRADES 3–5

40 MINUTES

RESEARCH SKILLS + CLOSE READING

SESSION GOALS

Students will: use the exhibition and library resources to practise research skills; connect primary sources (poems, art, music) to historical context; develop descriptive and analytical writing; and understand how the library is a portal to the past — the stories here are the same ones the Harlem Renaissance artists were creating.

PREPARATION

- Pull and display: 8–10 relevant library books (see recommendations page 2)
- Tables set: differentiated activity cards, pencils; optionally set up 2–3 research stations with books open to relevant sections
- Project: Great Migration Map and one Douglas image for whole-group opening

SESSION FLOW

- 0–5 min** **Opening Hook:** Show the Great Migration Map. *"In 1915, a Black family in Georgia could be arrested for almost nothing, couldn't vote, and would never own the land they farmed. A letter arrives from Chicago: 'Come north. There are factory jobs. The schools are better.' Over the next 50 years, 6 million people made that decision. The whole of Harlem changed because of it. Today we're going to look at what they created when they got there."*
- 5–12 min** **Whole-Group Reading:** Read aloud one Langston Hughes poem (teacher choice — "I, Too" works well; "Mother to Son" also excellent). Ask: What do you notice about the language? Who is speaking? What is the argument? How is this poem like a letter, a protest, and a prayer all at once?
- 12–17 min** **Art and Source Look:** Show Douglas *Song of the Towers*. Quick pair-share: two observations + one question. Introduce the idea that the painting and the poem were made at the same time, in the same neighbourhood — Douglas and Hughes knew each other.
- 17–35 min** **Activity Cards:** Students work on differentiated cards. Encourage library book use for Red-level research task. Circulate and ask probing questions: "How do you know? Where's your evidence? What else does this make you wonder?"
- 35–40 min** **Share and Close:** One student each from Yellow and Red shares their most interesting finding. *"The books on these shelves are a direct line to the people we studied today. The library is where their voices are still alive."*

Mini Museum Connection

Option 1 — Visit the Exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit. **Option 2 — Virtual Visit:** minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

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BOOK RECOMMENDATIONS — GRADES 3–5

Biography and History

- *Langston Hughes: A Biography* — Milton Meltzer — comprehensive, accessible
- *Voice of Freedom: Fannie Lou Hamer* — Carole Boston Weatherford — award-winning format
- *Zora Hurston and the Chinaberry Tree* — William Miller — picture-book biography
- *Duke Ellington: The Piano Prince* — Andrea Davis Pinkney — excellent at this level
- *Stompin' at the Savoy* — Karen Deans — Lindy Hop at the Savoy Ballroom

Primary Text Access

- *Poetry for Young People: Langston Hughes* — selected with classroom notes
- *The Dream Keeper and Other Poems* — Langston Hughes — designed for young readers
- *Soul Looks Back in Wonder* — Tom Feelings — anthology with Harlem Renaissance figures
- *Harlem Renaissance: A Brief History with Documents* — higher level, for Red extension
- Online: Poetry Foundation (poets.org) has all Hughes poems freely accessible

RESEARCH SKILLS INTEGRATION

This session is an ideal opportunity to integrate research skills instruction:

- **Finding a book:** Model using the catalogue to find Harlem Renaissance books by subject heading
- **Using an index:** Show students how to use the index in a biography to find specific information quickly
- **Evaluating sources:** Ask: what's the difference between reading a poem Langston Hughes wrote vs reading a book about Langston Hughes? Which is a primary source?
- **Note-taking:** Red-level students should practise paraphrasing — not copying — from sources they find